

A Prayer for my Daughter

HSE71 -A

W. B. Yeats - 1865-1939

Once more the storm is howling, and half hid Under
 this cradle-hood and coverlid
 My child sleeps on. There is no obstacle
 But Gregory's wood and one bare hill
 Whereby the haystack- and roof-levelling wind, Bred
 on the Atlantic, can be stayed;
 And for an hour I have walked and prayed Because
 of the great gloom that is in my mind.

I have walked and prayed for this young child an hour
 And heard the sea-wind scream upon the tower,
 And under the arches of the bridge, and scream In
 the elms above the flooded stream;
 maging in excited reverie
 That the future years had come,
 Dancing to a frenzied drum,
 Out of the murderous innocence of the sea.

May she be granted beauty and yet not
 Beauty to make a stranger's eye distraught,
 Or hers before a looking-glass, for such,
 Being made beautiful overmuch,
 Consider beauty a sufficient end,
 Lose natural kindness and maybe
 The heart-revealing intimacy
 That chooses right, and never find a friend.

Helen being chosen found life flat and dull
 And later had much trouble from a fool,
 While that great Queen, that rose out of the spray,
 Being fatherless could have her way
 Yet chose a bandy-legged smith for man.
 It's certain that fine women eat
 A crazy salad with their meat
 Whereby the Horn of Plenty is undone.

In courtesy I'd have her chiefly learned;
 Hearts are not had as a gift but hearts are earned
 By those that are not entirely beautiful;
 Yet many, that have played the fool
 For beauty's very self, has charm made wise, And
 many a poor man that has roved,

Loved and thought himself beloved,
 From a glad kindness cannot take his eyes.

May she become a flourishing hidden tree

That all her thoughts may like the linnet be,
 And have no business but dispensing round
 Their magnanimities of sound,
 Nor but in merriment begin a chase,
 Nor but in merriment a quarrel.
 O may she live like some green laurel
 Rooted in one dear perpetual place.

My mind, because the minds that I have loved, The
 sort of beauty that I have approved,
 Prosper but little, has dried up of late,
 Yet knows that to be choked with hate
 May well be of all evil chances chief.
 If there's no hatred in a mind
 Assault and battery of the wind
 Can never tear the linnet from the leaf.

An intellectual hatred is the worst,
 So let her think opinions are accursed.
 Have I not seen the loveliest woman born
 Out of the mouth of Plenty's horn,
 Because of her opinionated mind
 Barter that horn and every good
 By quiet natures understood
 For an old bellows full of angry wind?

Considering that, all hatred driven hence,
 The soul recovers radical innocence
 And learns at last that it is self-delighting,
 Self-appeasing, self-affrighting,
 And that its own sweet will is Heaven's will;
 She can, though every face should scowl
 And every windy quarter howl
 Or every bellows burst, be happy still.

And may her bridegroom bring her to a house
 Where all's accustomed, ceremonious;
 For arrogance and hatred are the wares
 Peddled in the thoroughfares.
 How but in custom and in ceremony
 Are innocence and beauty born?
 Ceremony's a name for the rich horn,
 And custom for the spreading laurel tree

William Butler Yeats (1865 – 1939)

- He is an Irish poet, dramatist (26) and a writer
- He was awarded Nobel Prize in Literature in 1923 - first Irish Nobel Laureate

- He was a driving force behind the **Irish Literary Revival**
 - One of the founders of **Abbey Theatre** - National theatre of Ireland - was an instrumental in propagating Irish Nationalism - along with Lady Gregory (1904)
 - He was a protestant in Catholic Ireland
 - He is famously in love with **Maud Gonne**, a Catholic Irish Nationalist (married to MacBride)
 - Thoor Ballylee Castle is known as Yeats' Tower in County Galway, Ireland
 - he owned this tower in around 1916
 - It has been described as "the most important public building in Ireland" by Seamus Heaney.
 - He wrote an introduction to Gitanjali by Tagore
 - Self-penned Epitaph
 - "Cast a cold eye on life, on death, horseman, pass by"
 - It is taken from his poem *Under Ben Bulbin* **Facts about the Poem**
 - This poem is written in 1919
 - This poem is more personal and perhaps more peaceful and optimistic
 - It was written two days after his daughter birth - Anne (February 26, 1919)
 - He married Georgie Hyde-Lees (20 October 1917)
 - It is also set on the backdrop of Post-World War I
 - The Irish War of Independence had begun just before he wrote the poem
 - First appeared in the poetry collection *Michael Robartes and the Dance* (1921)
 - "The Second Coming" and "Easter, 1916," also appeared in that volume
 - The poem was composed while he was staying in the famous tower - Thoor Ballylee Castle
 - This poem considered as significant work of Modernist poetry
 - A Prayer for my Son (1928)
 - A poem following the birth of Anne's younger brother, Michael,
 - It was published in his collection, The Tower
 - That poem is a kind of companion piece to "A Prayer for my Daughter."
- Vocabulary**
- **Gregory's Wood:** A forest near Thoor Ballylee, the "tower" where Yeats was living with his newborn daughter, Anne, when he wrote the poem.
 - **Tower:** This word refers to an actual tower in County Galway, Ireland, called Thoor Ballylee. Yeats was living there with his newborn daughter, Anne, when he wrote the poem.
 - **Reverie:** A daydream, usually a pleasant one. Here, however, the speaker seems more agitated than pleased by his "excited reverie."
 - **Looking-Glass:** A mirror.
 - **Helen:** Helen of Troy, said to have been the most beautiful woman in the world. In Greek myth, Helen was "chosen" to be the wife of Menelaus. According to some sources, she found life with him to be boring, which led her to go to Troy (some say she went willingly, others that she was kidnapped) with Paris, her lover and the "fool" the poem refers to. The elopement of Helen and Paris set off the massive "trouble" of the Trojan War
 - **Great Queen:** The Greek goddess Aphrodite, frequently associated with love and beauty. Aphrodite was born in the waves of the ocean and had no father. Though she could have had any man in the world, she chose Hephaestus, a blacksmith, as her husband.
 - **Spray:** Vapor, froth, or foam formed at the surface of ocean waves. According to Greek myth, the "great Queen" Aphrodite was born out of such spray.
 - **Bandy-Legged:** Being bowlegged, or having legs that curve outward at the knees. In the poem, the phrase refers to the blacksmith Hephaestus, Aphrodite's husband, who was lame.
 - **Crazy Salad:** Expresses the idea that overly beautiful women, like Helen and Aphrodite, squander their beauty and good fortune by doing crazy, senseless things and getting distracted from what really matters (the "meat" of life). The phrase might also refer to the ways beautiful women cheat on their husbands (or "their meat") with men they find more attractive. Helen eloped to Troy with Paris, and Aphrodite cheated on Hephaestus with Ares and many others.
 - **Horn of Plenty:** A cornucopia, or large horn-shaped vessel overflowing with fruits, vegetables, nuts, flowers, and other natural riches. In mythology and in the poem, the horn represents abundance, good fortune, and the blessings of the natural world, especially the natural beauty of women. According to the poem, women who are too physically beautiful waste their natural gifts and "undo[]" the Horn of Plenty.
 - **Linnet:** A European finch, often referenced in poetry and known for its pleasing song.
 - **Magnanimities:** Things that are pleasant, calm, generous, noble, or otherwise uplifted and distinguished in spirit. Used to compare the daughter's thoughts to the pleasing sound of the linnet's song.
 - **Laurel:** A fragrant, evergreen tree that was

important in ancient Greece and is often associated with poetry.

- **Maud Gonnet:** Yeats's lifelong, fraught relationship with Maud Gonnet also informs the poem in key ways. Yeats met Gonnet, a great beauty and fellow artist and Irish Nationalist, in 1889. They established a close relationship and she became his muse, but she rejected all of his repeated marriage proposals. Gonnet eventually married Major John MacBride, though the marriage fell apart in 1906 (the speaker refers to MacBride as "an old bellows full of angry wind"). - . Maud Gonnet had consummated a relationship with Lucien Millevoye – with two illegitimate children – and gone on to marry John MacBride
- **Georgie Hyde-Lees:** In 1917, he married Georgie Hyde-Lees (known as George), and in 1919 their first child, Anne, was born, prompting Yeats to write "A Prayer for my Daughter." Though Yeats seemed to have found some happiness with George, "A Prayer for my Daughter" indicates the lingering resentment he felt toward Gonnet, who he felt wasted her beauty and brought chaos and suffering into the world.

Structure, Form and Metre

- Written in the lyric form
- 80 lines broken up into 8 lined 10 stanzas (octets or octaves)
- Same Stanza structure of 'In Memory of Major Robert Gregory'
- Follows a regular rhyme Scheme - AABBCDDC
- Each stanza has two rhymed couplets (AABB) followed by a quatrain (CDDC)
- Each stanza acts as a self-contained unit
- Metre - Iambic Pentameter and Iambic Tetrameter
- In each stanza:
- 1, 2, 3, 5, and 8 are in iambic pentameter
- 4, 6, and 7 are iambic tetrameter.
- Tone - A conversational didactic tone
- Thematically divided into three
- Stanzas 1 and 2 set the scene, describe the violence of the storm, and express the speaker's "great gloom," which prompts the rest of the poem (the actual prayer) that follows.
- Stanzas 3 through 8 express some of the speaker's hopes and dreams for his daughter and warn against excess beauty and hateful opinions.
- 3 and 4 Stanza : Yeats' First desire for his daughter - to be kind and generous
- 5 and 6 Stanza : Yeats' Second desire for his daughter - to be courteous.
- 7 and 8 Stanza : Yeats' Third desire for his daughter - wants against intellectual hat redness

- Stanzas 9 and 10 paint a peaceful and pleasant final picture of the "radical innocence" the speaker hopes his daughter will achieve by following the path of "custom" and "ceremony."

Poetic Devices

- **Onomatopoeia:** the use of words that sound like the thing that they are describing
- howling, scream, spray, choke, scowl, howl
- **Repetition:** saying the same thing many times
- in the ninth stanza: self-appeasing, self-delighting, and self-affrighting
- **Alliteration**
- howling, and half hid, cradle-hood and coverlid, great gloom, sea-wind scream, being made beautiful, like the linnet, live like, linnet from the leaf, hatred driven hence, recovers radical, bellows burst, bridegroom bring, find a friend
- **Assonance:** similarity in the vowel sounds of words that are close together in a poem)
- such-over much, beauty-very, poor-roved, loved-thought-beloved, hidden-tree, linnet-leaf, should scowl
- **Metaphor:**
- Ceremony is used for the Plenty's horn, custom is used for the spreading laurel tree, linnet is used for good faith, and laurel is used for having a victorious life
- **Personification:**
- Sea-wind scream-human being, years...dancing-human being, frenzied drum - human being, angry wind- human being, "Assault and battery of the wind"
- **Simile:**
- "all her thoughts may like the linnet be", "may she live like some green laurel"

oxymoron

- murderous innocence of the sea

McQs

1. W.B. Yeats was born on
13th June 1865
2. W.B. Yeats' father was a popular
Irish Painter
3. W.B. Yeats was born in
Dublin
4. He was awarded the Nobel Prize in
1923
5. He was one of the founders of the famous.....
in Dublin
Abbey Theatre
6. He was appointed as.....of the Irish Free State
A Senator

7. This poem was originally published in Yeats' collection of poems
Michael Robarters and the dancer (1921)
8. This poem was written in
1919
9. This poem was first published in
1921
10. Which political event heavily influenced W.B. Yeats
Irish War of Independence
11. was the wife of W.B. Yeats
Georgie Hyde Less
12. What was the name of his daughter
Anne
13. was his famous beloved
Moud Gonne
14. An intellectual is the worst
Hatred
15. The poem begins by describing
Storm
16. The Storm symbolise in the poem
The Irish war of Independence
17. was the common theme of Yeats' poetry
Conflict between Ireland and the United Kingdom
18. This poem has stanzas
10
19. How many lines are there in each Stanza
8
20. The poem opens with an image of the new born child in a cradle
Sleeping
21. Where is the poet's daughter sleeping
In a cradle
22. is the name of wood near the poet's tower
Gregory's wood
23. The sea-wind is blowing
Against the tower, under the bridge, through the elm trees
24. would leave the his daughter friendless
Her Beauty
25. Who is the great Queen referred in the poem
Aphrodite
26. The 'fool' mentioned in stanza 4 of the poem is
Paris
27. Who was Aphrodite married to
Hephaestus
28. 'Horn of Plenty' is a symbol of
Abundance and Nourishment
29. What does the word 'linnet' refer to in this poem
A Bird
30. What quality of a laurel tree does the speaker intend to have in his daughter
Rootedness
31. What will be the worst of all evils?
Hatred
32. can ruin a blunt of beauty
Hateful opinions
33. is the last wish of WB Yeats in the poem
His daughter should marry a person of aristocratic family
34. This poem is a prayer for in a damaged civilisation
Order and grace
35. is the speaker of the poem
The poet himself
36. Where did the storm originate from
Atlantic Ocean
37. What Yeats consider as disastrous
Being the most beautiful
38. What qualities Yeats wants in his daughter
Natural kindness and Courtesy
39. Murderous Innocence is an example of
Paradox / Oximoron
40. What kind of family will be the best for his daughter
Traditional Family
41. What is the duration of the poet's prayer for his daughter?
One Hour
42. Poet compares beauty to
Helen and Aphrodite
43. Which kind of hatred does the poet think is the worst?
Intellectual Hatred
44. Which kind of tree does the poet use as a comparison
Flourishing and hide
45. What kind of bridegroom does Yeats expect for his daughter?
Well-cultured and ceremonious
46. What are the two places where the speaker can find beauty and innocence
Ceremony and Custom
47. Yeats died on
28th January 1939